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25 RECIPES + 6 BAKING LESSONS

Cake Baking for Beginners

A Practical Handbook for Learning to Bake Cakes with Confidence

NATURAL WELLNESS LIBRARY

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Always check ingredient labels for allergens before serving to guests.

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PART 1

Baking Fundamentals

Six short lessons covering the tools, techniques, and troubleshooting that make the rest of this book easier to use. Read these once before you start baking, then come back to them whenever something doesn't go as expected.

The Tools and Ingredients You Actually Need

You don't need a kitchen full of gadgets to bake a good cake. A digital kitchen scale is the single most useful tool you can own, because weighing flour and sugar is far more accurate than scooping with cups. Beyond that, a couple of mixing bowls, a whisk, a rubber spatula, measuring spoons, and two or three cake pans will cover almost everything in this book.

For ingredients, keep the basics on hand: all-purpose flour, granulated sugar, unsalted butter, eggs, whole milk, baking powder, baking soda, salt, and vanilla extract. Most of the recipes that follow build from this same short list, which is part of why they're a good place to learn.

- Digital kitchen scale (grams are more forgiving to measure accurately than cups)
- Two mixing bowls, one large and one medium
- A balloon whisk and a rubber or silicone spatula
- Measuring spoons for small quantities like baking powder and salt
- Two 8- or 9-inch round cake pans, or one 9×13-inch pan
- A wire cooling rack
- An oven thermometer, since many home ovens run hotter or cooler than their dial suggests

How to Measure Flour, Sugar, Butter, and Liquids Accurately

Measuring by weight removes most of the guesswork from baking. One cup of flour can weigh anywhere from 120 to 150 grams depending on how it's scooped, and that difference is enough to make a cake dry or dense. If you have a scale, use it; every recipe in this book lists both.

If you're measuring flour by cup because you don't have a scale yet, spoon the flour into the measuring cup until it's heaped, then level it off with the flat side of a knife. Never scoop directly from the bag and pack it down, since that can add 20 to 30 percent more flour than the recipe intends.

Sugar is more forgiving, since it doesn't compress the way flour does, but still spoon it in and level it for consistency. Butter is usually sold with measurement markings on the wrapper; follow those, or weigh it for a precise amount. For liquids, use a clear measuring cup with a spout, set it on a flat surface, and check the measurement at eye level rather than looking down at it.

- Spoon flour into the cup, then level with a knife — never scoop and pack
- Weigh ingredients in grams whenever a scale is available
- Check liquid measurements at eye level, on a flat surface
- Room-temperature butter and eggs blend more evenly than cold ones

Preparing Pans and Understanding Oven Temperatures

Grease your pan with a thin layer of butter or non-stick spray, then line the bottom with a circle of parchment paper. This combination keeps the cake from sticking even along the edges, which greasing alone doesn't always manage. For a loaf or square pan, you can line the whole pan with a single sheet of parchment, leaving an overhang on two sides to lift the cake out.

Always preheat the oven fully before the cake goes in — at least 15 minutes for most home ovens. An oven that hasn't reached temperature will bake the outside of the cake slowly while the inside sets unevenly, since the heat climbs gradually instead of starting strong.

Oven thermometers are worth the small cost. Many ovens run 15 to 25 degrees F off from what the dial shows, which is enough to change a recipe's timing noticeably. If your cakes consistently finish early or late, check your oven's actual temperature before assuming the recipe is wrong.

- Grease the pan, then line the bottom with parchment paper
- Preheat fully — don't open the oven door to check if it's ready
- Place the pan on the center rack unless a recipe says otherwise
- An oven thermometer reveals if your dial runs hot or cold

Creaming, Mixing, and Folding: The Four Basic Techniques

Creaming means beating butter and sugar together until the mixture turns pale and fluffy, usually 2 to 4 minutes with an electric mixer. This step beats tiny air pockets into the butter, which is part of what gives a cake its light texture, so don't rush past it.

Mixing refers to combining the wet and dry ingredients. The usual method is to add the dry ingredients and liquid in alternating additions — dry, wet, dry, wet, dry — starting and ending with dry. This prevents the batter from curdling or turning tough from overmixing.

Folding is a gentle technique used for airy mixtures like whipped egg whites or whipped cream, where you don't want to beat out the air you just added. Use a spatula to cut down through the center of the bowl, then sweep along the bottom and up the side, turning the bowl slightly as you go, repeating until just combined.

Once flour is added, mix only until you no longer see dry streaks. Overmixing develops gluten in the flour, which makes a cake tough and chewy instead of tender.

- Creaming: butter and sugar beaten until pale and fluffy
- Alternating method: dry, wet, dry, wet, dry — start and end with dry
- Folding: gentle, for airy mixtures like whipped cream or egg whites
- Stop mixing as soon as the batter looks combined — overmixing toughens cake

Checking Doneness and Cooling Cakes Correctly

A cake is usually done when it pulls slightly away from the sides of the pan, springs back when lightly pressed in the center, and a toothpick inserted in the middle comes out clean or with a few moist crumbs (not wet batter). Start checking a few minutes before the recipe's stated time, since ovens vary.

Let the cake cool in the pan for 10 to 15 minutes before turning it out. This gives it time to firm up enough to hold its shape; a cake turned out too early can crack or stick to the pan. After that, run a thin knife around the edge, invert the cake onto a rack, and let it cool completely — usually an hour or more — before frosting.

Frosting a warm cake is one of the most common beginner mistakes. Warm cake will melt buttercream into a greasy mess and make glazes run off entirely. If you're in a hurry, you can speed cooling by placing the cake (still on its rack) in the refrigerator for 20 to 30 minutes once it's no longer hot to the touch.

- Toothpick test: clean or a few moist crumbs, not wet batter
- Cool in the pan 10-15 minutes before turning out
- Cool completely on a rack before frosting — warm cake melts frosting
- Refrigerating a cooled (not hot) cake for 20-30 minutes speeds things up

Why Cakes Sink, Dry Out, or Bake Unevenly

A sunken center is usually caused by one of three things: the oven door was opened too early (before the structure had set), too much leavening (baking powder or soda) was used, or the cake was underbaked and taken out before it finished setting. If this happens repeatedly, try waiting longer before your first oven check and confirming your oven temperature is accurate.

A dry cake is most often the result of too much flour (usually from scooping instead of weighing), overbaking, or too little fat or liquid in the batter. Measuring by weight and checking doneness a few minutes early both help prevent this.

A dense, heavy cake usually means the butter and sugar weren't creamed long enough to add air, or the batter was overmixed after the flour went in, collapsing the air bubbles that give cake its lift. A gummy layer at the bottom can mean the cake needed a few more minutes in the oven, or that it was turned out of the pan before it had cooled enough to hold together.

Uneven baking — one side rising higher than the other — is often an oven issue rather than a recipe issue. Hot spots are common in home ovens; rotating the pan halfway through baking (quickly, without letting too much heat escape) usually fixes it.

- Sunken center: oven opened too early, too much leavening, or underbaked
- Dry cake: too much flour, overbaked, or not enough fat/liquid
- Dense cake: undercreamed butter and sugar, or overmixed batter
- Uneven rise: rotate the pan halfway through baking for oven hot spots

PART 2

Everyday Cakes

Simple, reliable cakes built on the same handful of techniques from Part One — good for learning the basics and for baking on an ordinary day.

Classic Yellow Butter Cake

The cake to learn on: simple, reliable, and a good test of the creaming method.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 30-35 MIN • TWO 8-INCH ROUND PANS • 350F/175C • 10-12 SLICES

CAKE

- 2 1/2 cups (315g) all-purpose flour
- 1 3/4 cups (350g) granulated sugar
- 1 cup (226g) unsalted butter, softened
- 4 large eggs, room temperature
- 1 cup (240ml) whole milk, room temperature
- 2 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/2 tsp salt
- 2 tsp vanilla extract

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Grease two 8-inch pans and line the bottoms with parchment.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, and salt together in a bowl and set aside.
3. Beat the butter and sugar together on medium speed for 3-4 minutes, until pale and fluffy.
4. Add the eggs one at a time, beating well after each, then mix in the vanilla.
5. With the mixer on low, add the flour mixture in three additions, alternating with the milk in two additions, starting and ending with flour. Mix just until combined.
6. Divide the batter between the pans and smooth the tops. Bake 30-35 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.

7. Cool in the pans 10 minutes, then turn out onto a rack to cool completely before frosting.

Storage: Unfrosted layers keep wrapped at room temperature for 2 days, or frozen up to 2 months.

Moist Chocolate Cake

Uses hot coffee to deepen the chocolate flavor without tasting like coffee.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 32-36 MIN • TWO 8-INCH ROUND PANS • 350F/175C • 10-12 SLICES

CAKE

- 2 cups (250g) all-purpose flour
- 2 cups (400g) granulated sugar
- 3/4 cup (65g) unsweetened cocoa powder
- 2 tsp baking soda
- 1 tsp baking powder
- 1 tsp salt
- 2 large eggs, room temperature
- 1 cup (240ml) buttermilk
- 1/2 cup (120ml) vegetable oil
- 2 tsp vanilla extract
- 1 cup (240ml) hot coffee or hot water

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Grease two 8-inch pans and line the bottoms with parchment.
2. Whisk the flour, sugar, cocoa, baking soda, baking powder, and salt together in a large bowl.
3. Add the eggs, buttermilk, oil, and vanilla, and whisk until smooth.
4. Stir in the hot coffee last — the batter will be thin, which is expected.
5. Divide between the pans and bake 32-36 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool in the pans 10 minutes, then turn out onto a rack to cool completely.

Storage: Keeps wrapped at room temperature for 3 days, or frozen up to 2 months.

Allergens: Contains wheat, egg, and dairy (from buttermilk).

Simple Vanilla Snack Cake

A one-bowl cake for when you want something homemade without the layering.

PREP 10 MIN • BAKE 28-30 MIN • ONE 9X13-INCH PAN • 350F/175C • 12-15 SQUARES

CAKE

- 2 1/4 cups (280g) all-purpose flour
- 1 1/2 cups (300g) granulated sugar
- 1/2 cup (113g) unsalted butter, melted
- 2 large eggs
- 1 cup (240ml) whole milk
- 2 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/2 tsp salt
- 1 tbsp vanilla extract

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Grease a 9×13-inch pan.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, and salt in a large bowl.
3. In a separate bowl, whisk the melted butter, sugar, eggs, milk, and vanilla until smooth.
4. Pour the wet ingredients into the dry and whisk just until no dry streaks remain.
5. Pour into the pan and bake 28-30 minutes, until golden and a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool at least 20 minutes before cutting. Good plain, dusted with powdered sugar, or lightly frosted.

Storage: Covered at room temperature for 3 days.

Lemon Buttermilk Cake

Buttermilk and fresh lemon zest keep this cake tender and bright.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 30-34 MIN • ONE 9-INCH ROUND PAN • 350F/175C • 8-10 SLICES

CAKE

- 2 cups (250g) all-purpose flour
- 1 1/2 cups (300g) granulated sugar
- 1/2 cup (113g) unsalted butter, softened
- 2 large eggs
- 1 cup (240ml) buttermilk
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 1/2 tsp baking soda
- 1/2 tsp salt
- Zest of 2 lemons
- 3 tbsp fresh lemon juice

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Grease a 9-inch pan and line the bottom with parchment.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, baking soda, and salt together.
3. Beat the butter, sugar, and lemon zest until pale and fragrant, about 3 minutes.
4. Add the eggs one at a time, then the lemon juice.
5. Alternate adding the flour mixture and buttermilk in three additions each, starting and ending with flour.
6. Pour into the pan and bake 30-34 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
7. Cool 10 minutes in the pan, then turn out to cool completely.

Storage: Keeps covered at room temperature for 3 days.

Banana Cake with Brown Sugar

A good use for very ripe bananas — the riper, the better the flavor.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 32-36 MIN • ONE 9X13-INCH PAN • 350F/175C • 12-15 SQUARES

CAKE

- 2 1/2 cups (315g) all-purpose flour
- 1 cup (200g) packed brown sugar
- 1/2 cup (100g) granulated sugar
- 1/2 cup (113g) unsalted butter, softened
- 2 large eggs
- 3 very ripe bananas, mashed (about 1 1/4 cups)
- 1/2 cup (120ml) whole milk
- 1 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/2 tsp baking soda
- 1/2 tsp salt
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Grease a 9×13-inch pan.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, baking soda, and salt in a bowl.
3. Beat the butter and both sugars until fluffy, about 3 minutes. Add the eggs one at a time, then the mashed banana and vanilla.
4. Alternate adding the flour mixture and milk, starting and ending with flour, mixing just until combined.
5. Pour into the pan and bake 32-36 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool completely before frosting or dusting with powdered sugar.

Storage: Keeps covered at room temperature for 3 days, or refrigerated for a week.

Carrot Cake with Walnuts

A straightforward spiced carrot cake, pairs well with cream cheese frosting.

PREP 20 MIN • BAKE 30-34 MIN • TWO 8-INCH ROUND PANS • 350F/175C • 10-12 SLICES

CAKE

- 2 cups (250g) all-purpose flour
- 1 1/2 cups (300g) granulated sugar
- 1 cup (240ml) vegetable oil
- 4 large eggs
- 3 cups finely grated carrots (about 4-5 medium)
- 1 cup (100g) chopped walnuts
- 2 tsp baking soda
- 1 tsp baking powder
- 1 tsp salt
- 2 tsp ground cinnamon
- 1/2 tsp ground nutmeg

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Grease two 8-inch pans and line the bottoms with parchment.
2. Whisk the flour, baking soda, baking powder, salt, cinnamon, and nutmeg together.
3. In a separate bowl, whisk the oil, sugar, and eggs until smooth.
4. Fold the dry ingredients into the wet until just combined, then fold in the grated carrots and walnuts.
5. Divide between the pans and bake 30-34 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool in the pans 10 minutes, then turn out to cool completely before frosting.

Storage: Keeps refrigerated, well wrapped, for up to 5 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat, egg, and tree nuts (walnuts).

Spiced Applesauce Cake

Unsweetened applesauce keeps this cake moist without needing much added fat.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 35-40 MIN • ONE 9-INCH ROUND PAN OR LOAF PAN • 350F/175C • 8-10 SLICES

CAKE

- 2 cups (250g) all-purpose flour
- 1 cup (200g) packed brown sugar
- 1/3 cup (75g) unsalted butter, melted
- 2 large eggs
- 1 1/2 cups (360g) unsweetened applesauce
- 1 1/2 tsp baking soda
- 1/2 tsp salt
- 1 1/2 tsp ground cinnamon
- 1/4 tsp ground cloves
- 1/4 tsp ground ginger

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Grease a 9-inch round or loaf pan and line with parchment.
2. Whisk the flour, baking soda, salt, cinnamon, cloves, and ginger together.
3. In another bowl, whisk the melted butter, brown sugar, eggs, and applesauce until smooth.
4. Fold the dry ingredients into the wet just until combined.
5. Pour into the pan and bake 35-40 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool in the pan 10 minutes, then turn out to cool completely.

Storage: Keeps covered at room temperature for 4 days.

Honey Spice Cake

Honey adds moisture and a mild floral sweetness alongside warm spices.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 30-34 MIN • ONE 9-INCH SQUARE PAN • 350F/175C • 9 SQUARES

CAKE

- 2 cups (250g) all-purpose flour
- 1/2 cup (170g) honey
- 1/2 cup (100g) packed brown sugar
- 1/2 cup (113g) unsalted butter, softened
- 2 large eggs
- 3/4 cup (180ml) whole milk
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 1/2 tsp salt
- 1 1/2 tsp ground cinnamon
- 1/2 tsp ground allspice

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Grease a 9-inch square pan.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, salt, cinnamon, and allspice together.
3. Beat the butter, honey, and brown sugar together until fluffy, about 3 minutes. Add the eggs one at a time.
4. Alternate adding the flour mixture and milk, starting and ending with flour.
5. Pour into the pan and bake 30-34 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool 15 minutes before cutting.

Storage: Keeps covered at room temperature for 3 days.

Buttermilk Spice Cake

A simpler cousin of carrot cake — same warm spices, without the grating.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 30-33 MIN • ONE 9-INCH ROUND PAN • 350F/175C • 8-10 SLICES

CAKE

- 2 cups (250g) all-purpose flour
- 1 1/4 cups (250g) granulated sugar
- 1/2 cup (113g) unsalted butter, softened
- 2 large eggs
- 1 cup (240ml) buttermilk
- 1 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/2 tsp baking soda
- 1/2 tsp salt
- 1 1/2 tsp ground cinnamon
- 1/4 tsp ground nutmeg
- 1/4 tsp ground cloves

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Grease a 9-inch pan and line the bottom with parchment.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, baking soda, salt, and spices together.
3. Beat the butter and sugar until fluffy, about 3 minutes, then add the eggs one at a time.
4. Alternate adding the flour mixture and buttermilk, starting and ending with flour.
5. Pour into the pan and bake 30-33 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool in the pan 10 minutes, then turn out to cool completely.

Storage: Keeps covered at room temperature for 3 days.

PART 3

Cakes That Teach a Technique

Each of these cakes introduces one specific skill: full creaming for pound cake, folding for sponge and angel food, swirling for marble cake.

Classic Pound Cake

A dense, buttery cake that teaches patience — low, slow heat and full creaming.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 55-65 MIN • ONE 9X5-INCH LOAF PAN • 325F/160C • 10-12 SLICES

CAKE

- 2 cups (250g) all-purpose flour
- 1 1/2 cups (300g) granulated sugar
- 1 cup (226g) unsalted butter, softened
- 4 large eggs, room temperature
- 1/2 cup (120ml) whole milk
- 1 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/2 tsp salt
- 2 tsp vanilla extract

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 325F/160C. Grease a 9×5-inch loaf pan and line with parchment, leaving an overhang.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, and salt together.
3. Beat the butter and sugar on medium speed for a full 5 minutes, until very pale and fluffy — this step matters more here than in most cakes.
4. Add the eggs one at a time, beating well after each, then the vanilla.
5. Alternate adding the flour mixture and milk in three additions, starting and ending with flour. Mix just until smooth.
6. Pour into the pan and bake 55-65 minutes, until deeply golden and a toothpick comes out clean.

7. Cool in the pan 15 minutes, then lift out using the parchment overhang to cool completely on a rack.

Storage: Keeps wrapped at room temperature for 4 days.

Marble Cake

A chance to practice swirling two batters without overmixing them together.

PREP 20 MIN • BAKE 45-50 MIN • ONE 9X5-INCH LOAF PAN OR BUNDT PAN • 350F/175C • 10-12 SLICES

VANILLA BATTER

- 2 1/4 cups (280g) all-purpose flour
- 1 1/2 cups (300g) granulated sugar
- 3/4 cup (170g) unsalted butter, softened
- 3 large eggs
- 3/4 cup (180ml) whole milk
- 2 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/2 tsp salt
- 1 tbsp vanilla extract

CHOCOLATE ADDITION

- 3 tbsp (25g) unsweetened cocoa powder
- 2 tbsp whole milk

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Grease a loaf or bundt pan.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, and salt together.
3. Beat the butter and sugar until fluffy, about 3 minutes. Add the eggs one at a time, then the vanilla.
4. Alternate adding the flour mixture and milk, starting and ending with flour.
5. Remove about a third of the batter to a separate bowl and stir in the cocoa powder and extra milk until smooth.
6. Spoon the two batters into the pan in alternating dollops, then drag a knife through in a few swirling motions — don't overmix or the marbling disappears.
7. Bake 45-50 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.

Storage: Keeps wrapped at room temperature for 3 days.

Classic Angel Food Cake

An exercise in whipping and folding egg whites instead of creaming butter.

PREP 20 MIN • BAKE 35-40 MIN • ONE 10-INCH TUBE PAN, UNGREASED • 325F/160C • 10-12 SLICES

CAKE

- 1 cup (120g) cake flour or all-purpose flour, sifted
- 1 1/2 cups (300g) granulated sugar, divided
- 12 large egg whites, room temperature
- 1 1/2 tsp cream of tartar
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 325F/160C. Do not grease the tube pan — the batter needs to cling to the sides to rise.
2. Sift the flour with half the sugar (3/4 cup) and set aside.
3. Beat the egg whites, cream of tartar, and salt on medium speed until foamy, then gradually add the remaining sugar and beat until stiff, glossy peaks form.
4. Beat in the vanilla, then sift the flour mixture over the whites in three additions, folding gently each time with a spatula.
5. Pour into the ungreased pan, smooth the top, and bake 35-40 minutes, until golden and springy to the touch.
6. Invert the pan immediately (most tube pans have feet for this) and let it cool completely upside down before releasing, about 2 hours.

Storage: Keeps covered at room temperature for 2 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat and egg.

Simple Sponge Cake

A lighter, less sweet cake, good plain with fruit or lightly dressed with cream.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 22-25 MIN • TWO 8-INCH ROUND PANS • 350F/175C • 8-10 SLICES

CAKE

- 1 cup (125g) all-purpose flour
- 3/4 cup (150g) granulated sugar, divided
- 4 large eggs, separated
- 1/4 cup (60ml) whole milk, warmed
- 1 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Grease two 8-inch pans and line the bottoms with parchment.
2. Whisk the flour and baking powder together.
3. Beat the egg yolks with half the sugar until pale and thick, then mix in the warm milk and vanilla.
4. In a separate clean bowl, beat the egg whites and salt until foamy, then gradually add the remaining sugar and beat to soft, glossy peaks.
5. Fold the flour into the yolk mixture, then gently fold in the egg whites in two additions.
6. Divide between the pans and bake 22-25 minutes, until pale golden and springy.
7. Cool in the pans 5 minutes, then turn out to cool completely.

Storage: Best the day it's made; keeps covered for 1-2 days.

Cinnamon Crumb Coffee Cake

A tender cake with a thick, buttery streusel layer baked into the top.

PREP 20 MIN • BAKE 35-40 MIN • ONE 9-INCH SQUARE PAN • 350F/175C • 9 SQUARES

CAKE

- 1 1/2 cups (190g) all-purpose flour
- 3/4 cup (150g) granulated sugar
- 1/3 cup (75g) unsalted butter, softened
- 1 large egg
- 3/4 cup (180ml) whole milk
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

CRUMB TOPPING

- 3/4 cup (95g) all-purpose flour
- 1/2 cup (100g) packed brown sugar
- 1 tsp ground cinnamon
- 6 tbsp (85g) unsalted butter, melted

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Grease a 9-inch square pan.
2. For the crumb topping, stir the flour, brown sugar, and cinnamon together, then stir in the melted butter until clumpy. Set aside.
3. For the cake, whisk the flour, baking powder, and salt together.
4. Beat the butter and sugar until fluffy, add the egg and vanilla, then alternate adding the flour mixture and milk, starting and ending with flour.
5. Spread the batter in the pan and scatter the crumb topping evenly over it.
6. Bake 35-40 minutes, until a toothpick inserted into the cake (not the topping) comes out clean.
7. Cool at least 20 minutes before cutting.

Storage: Keeps covered at room temperature for 3 days.

PART 4

More Everyday Baking

A second set of easy cakes and cupcakes for practicing portioning, spiced batters, and simple pan techniques.

Vanilla Bean Cupcakes

A small-batch version of the yellow cake method, for practicing portioning.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 18-20 MIN • 12-CUP MUFFIN TIN WITH LINERS • 350F/175C • 12 CUPCAKES

CUPCAKES

- 1 3/4 cups (220g) all-purpose flour
- 1 cup (200g) granulated sugar
- 1/2 cup (113g) unsalted butter, softened
- 2 large eggs
- 3/4 cup (180ml) whole milk
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 2 tsp vanilla bean paste or extract

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Line a muffin tin with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, and salt together.
3. Beat the butter and sugar until fluffy, about 3 minutes. Add the eggs one at a time, then the vanilla.
4. Alternate adding the flour mixture and milk, starting and ending with flour.
5. Divide the batter evenly among the liners, filling each about two-thirds full.
6. Bake 18-20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
7. Cool in the tin 5 minutes, then transfer to a rack to cool completely before frosting.

Storage: Unfrosted, keeps covered for 2 days.

Chocolate Cupcakes

Uses the same hot-coffee trick as the layer cake, scaled down.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 18-20 MIN • 12-CUP MUFFIN TIN WITH LINERS • 350F/175C • 12 CUPCAKES

CUPCAKES

- 1 cup (125g) all-purpose flour
- 1 cup (200g) granulated sugar
- 1/3 cup (30g) unsweetened cocoa powder
- 1 tsp baking soda
- 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/2 tsp salt
- 1 large egg
- 1/2 cup (120ml) buttermilk
- 1/4 cup (60ml) vegetable oil
- 1/2 cup (120ml) hot coffee or hot water

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Line a muffin tin with paper liners.
2. Whisk the flour, sugar, cocoa, baking soda, baking powder, and salt together.
3. Add the egg, buttermilk, and oil, and whisk until smooth, then stir in the hot coffee — the batter will be thin.
4. Divide among the liners, filling each about two-thirds full.
5. Bake 18-20 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool in the tin 5 minutes, then transfer to a rack to cool completely.

Storage: Unfrosted, keeps covered for 2 days.

Simple White Cake

Uses egg whites only, for a paler crumb and a slightly different texture than yellow cake.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 28-32 MIN • TWO 8-INCH ROUND PANS • 350F/175C • 10-12 SLICES

CAKE

- 2 1/4 cups (280g) all-purpose flour
- 1 3/4 cups (350g) granulated sugar
- 3/4 cup (170g) unsalted butter, softened
- 5 large egg whites, room temperature
- 1 cup (240ml) whole milk
- 2 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/2 tsp salt
- 1 1/2 tsp vanilla extract

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Grease two 8-inch pans and line the bottoms with parchment.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, and salt together.
3. Beat the butter and sugar until pale and fluffy, about 3 minutes.
4. In a separate bowl, whisk the egg whites, milk, and vanilla together, then add to the butter mixture alternately with the flour mixture, starting and ending with flour.
5. Divide between the pans and bake 28-32 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool in the pans 10 minutes, then turn out to cool completely.

Storage: Keeps wrapped at room temperature for 2 days.

Zucchini Cake

A good way to use up summer zucchini — the flavor is mild, the texture very moist.

PREP 20 MIN • BAKE 35-40 MIN • ONE 9X13-INCH PAN • 350F/175C • 12-15 SQUARES

CAKE

- 2 1/2 cups (315g) all-purpose flour
- 1 1/2 cups (300g) granulated sugar
- 1 cup (240ml) vegetable oil
- 3 large eggs
- 2 cups grated zucchini, squeezed lightly to remove excess liquid
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 1/2 tsp baking soda
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 1/2 tsp ground cinnamon

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Grease a 9×13-inch pan.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, baking soda, salt, and cinnamon together.
3. In a separate bowl, whisk the oil, sugar, and eggs until smooth.
4. Fold in the dry ingredients until just combined, then fold in the grated zucchini.
5. Pour into the pan and bake 35-40 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool completely before cutting or frosting.

Storage: Keeps refrigerated for up to 5 days.

Orange Olive Oil Cake

Olive oil gives this cake a moist, slightly dense crumb with a fruity edge.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 35-40 MIN • ONE 9-INCH ROUND PAN • 350F/175C • 8-10 SLICES

CAKE

- 2 cups (250g) all-purpose flour
- 1 1/4 cups (250g) granulated sugar
- 3/4 cup (180ml) extra-virgin olive oil
- 3 large eggs
- 3/4 cup (180ml) whole milk
- Zest of 2 oranges
- 1/4 cup fresh orange juice
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 1/2 tsp salt

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Grease a 9-inch pan and line the bottom with parchment.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, and salt together.
3. In a separate bowl, whisk the olive oil, sugar, eggs, milk, orange zest, and orange juice until smooth.
4. Fold the dry ingredients into the wet just until combined.
5. Pour into the pan and bake 35-40 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool in the pan 10 minutes, then turn out to cool completely.

Storage: Keeps covered at room temperature for 4 days — the flavor improves slightly the next day.

Classic Gingerbread Cake

A straightforward, deeply spiced molasses cake, good on its own or with whipped cream.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 35-38 MIN • ONE 9-INCH SQUARE PAN • 350F/175C • 9 SQUARES

CAKE

- 2 1/4 cups (280g) all-purpose flour
- 1/2 cup (100g) packed brown sugar
- 1/2 cup (170g) molasses
- 1/2 cup (113g) unsalted butter, melted
- 1 large egg
- 3/4 cup (180ml) hot water
- 1 1/2 tsp baking soda
- 1/2 tsp salt
- 2 tsp ground ginger
- 1 1/2 tsp ground cinnamon
- 1/4 tsp ground cloves

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Grease a 9-inch square pan.
2. Whisk the flour, baking soda, salt, ginger, cinnamon, and cloves together.
3. In a separate bowl, whisk the melted butter, brown sugar, molasses, and egg until smooth.
4. Add the dry ingredients and hot water alternately to the wet mixture, starting and ending with dry, whisking until smooth — the batter will be thin.
5. Pour into the pan and bake 35-38 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool at least 20 minutes before cutting.

Storage: Keeps covered at room temperature for 4 days; flavor deepens overnight.

PART 5

A Little Different

Cakes built around a single defining ingredient — olive oil, almond flour, coconut milk — to show how one swap changes texture and flavor.

Coconut Cake

A white-cake base built around coconut milk and shredded coconut.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 28-32 MIN • TWO 8-INCH ROUND PANS • 350F/175C • 10-12 SLICES

CAKE

- 2 1/4 cups (280g) all-purpose flour
- 1 3/4 cups (350g) granulated sugar
- 3/4 cup (170g) unsalted butter, softened
- 4 large egg whites, room temperature
- 1 cup (240ml) canned coconut milk
- 1 cup (85g) sweetened shredded coconut
- 2 1/2 tsp baking powder
- 1/2 tsp salt
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1/2 tsp coconut extract (optional)

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Grease two 8-inch pans and line the bottoms with parchment.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, and salt together.
3. Beat the butter and sugar until fluffy, about 3 minutes.
4. In a separate bowl, whisk the egg whites, coconut milk, vanilla, and coconut extract if using.
5. Add to the butter mixture alternately with the flour mixture, starting and ending with flour, then fold in the shredded coconut.

6. Divide between the pans and bake 28-32 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
7. Cool in the pans 10 minutes, then turn out to cool completely.

Storage: Keeps wrapped at room temperature for 2 days, or refrigerated for 5 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat, egg, and tree nut (coconut, for those with coconut sensitivity).

Classic Pumpkin Cake

A moist, spiced cake that works year-round, not just in autumn.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 32-36 MIN • ONE 9X13-INCH PAN • 350F/175C • 12-15 SQUARES

CAKE

- 2 cups (250g) all-purpose flour
- 1 1/2 cups (300g) granulated sugar
- 1 cup (240ml) vegetable oil
- 4 large eggs
- 1 can (15 oz / 425g) pumpkin puree
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 1 tsp baking soda
- 1/2 tsp salt
- 2 tsp ground cinnamon
- 1/2 tsp ground nutmeg
- 1/4 tsp ground cloves

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Grease a 9×13-inch pan.
2. Whisk the flour, baking powder, baking soda, salt, and spices together.
3. In a separate bowl, whisk the oil, sugar, eggs, and pumpkin puree until smooth.
4. Fold the dry ingredients into the wet just until combined.
5. Pour into the pan and bake 32-36 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool completely before frosting.

Storage: Keeps refrigerated, covered, for up to 5 days.

Almond Cake

Almond flour adds moisture and a mild nutty flavor without being a flourless cake.

PREP 15 MIN • BAKE 35-40 MIN • ONE 9-INCH ROUND PAN • 350F/175C • 8-10 SLICES

CAKE

- 1 1/2 cups (190g) all-purpose flour
- 1 cup (95g) almond flour
- 1 1/4 cups (250g) granulated sugar
- 3/4 cup (170g) unsalted butter, softened
- 3 large eggs
- 1/2 cup (120ml) whole milk
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 1/2 tsp salt
- 1 tsp almond extract
- 1/2 tsp vanilla extract

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Grease a 9-inch pan and line the bottom with parchment.
2. Whisk the all-purpose flour, almond flour, baking powder, and salt together.
3. Beat the butter and sugar until fluffy, about 3 minutes. Add the eggs one at a time, then the extracts.
4. Alternate adding the flour mixture and milk, starting and ending with flour.
5. Pour into the pan and bake 35-40 minutes, until golden and a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool in the pan 10 minutes, then turn out to cool completely.

Storage: Keeps covered at room temperature for 3 days.

Allergens: Contains wheat, egg, dairy, and tree nuts (almond).

Red Velvet Cake

A mild cocoa cake with a buttermilk tang, finished in the classic deep red shade.

PREP 20 MIN • BAKE 28-32 MIN • TWO 8-INCH ROUND PANS • 350F/175C • 10-12 SLICES

CAKE

- 2 1/2 cups (315g) all-purpose flour
- 1 1/2 cups (300g) granulated sugar
- 1/2 cup (113g) unsalted butter, softened
- 1/2 cup (120ml) vegetable oil
- 2 large eggs
- 1 cup (240ml) buttermilk
- 1 tbsp unsweetened cocoa powder
- 1 tsp baking soda
- 1/2 tsp salt
- 1 tsp white vinegar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 1-2 tbsp red food coloring

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C. Grease two 8-inch pans and line the bottoms with parchment.
2. Whisk the flour, cocoa, baking soda, and salt together.
3. Beat the butter, oil, and sugar until fluffy, about 3 minutes. Add the eggs one at a time.
4. Mix the buttermilk, vinegar, vanilla, and food coloring together, then alternate adding it with the flour mixture, starting and ending with flour.
5. Divide between the pans and bake 28-32 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
6. Cool in the pans 10 minutes, then turn out to cool completely before frosting (traditionally with cream cheese frosting).

Storage: Unfrosted, keeps wrapped at room temperature for 2 days.

Simple Fruit Upside-Down Cake

A technique more than a single recipe — works with pineapple, pears, or stone fruit.

PREP 20 MIN • BAKE 35-40 MIN • ONE 9-INCH ROUND PAN • 350F/175C • 8 SLICES

FRUIT TOPPING

- 1/4 cup (55g) unsalted butter
- 1/2 cup (100g) packed brown sugar
- 1 1/2 cups sliced fruit (pineapple, pears, or peaches)

CAKE

- 1 1/2 cups (190g) all-purpose flour
- 3/4 cup (150g) granulated sugar
- 1/3 cup (75g) unsalted butter, softened
- 2 large eggs
- 1/2 cup (120ml) whole milk
- 2 tsp baking powder
- 1/4 tsp salt
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 350F/175C.
2. Melt the butter in the cake pan directly (or in a saucepan, then pour into the pan). Sprinkle the brown sugar evenly over it, then arrange the fruit slices on top.
3. Whisk the flour, baking powder, and salt together.
4. Beat the butter and sugar until fluffy, add the eggs one at a time, then the vanilla.
5. Alternate adding the flour mixture and milk, starting and ending with flour.
6. Carefully spread the batter over the fruit layer and bake 35-40 minutes, until a toothpick comes out clean.
7. Cool 10 minutes, then run a knife around the edge and invert onto a serving plate while still warm.

Storage: Best the day it's made; keeps covered for 2 days.

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